

AKHILESH MALANI

Lead Accessibility Test Architect | Digital Inclusion and Assistive Technology SME

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Results-driven Lead Accessibility Architect and Subject Matter Expert with 16+ years of specialized experience spearheading digital accessibility (a11y), inclusive UX architecture, and global regulatory compliance across enterprise web, native mobile (iOS and Android), and digital document platforms. Combines daily lived experience as a blind professional using screen readers with deep engineering acumen to identify critical barriers, focus traps, and complex interaction flaws that automated scanning tools miss.

Proven track record leading high-impact accessibility initiatives for Tier-1 global organizations, including Bank of Montreal, Dun & Bradstreet, Google (Google Play and core products), and Oracle Financial Services. Creator of AMASAMYA, an open-source WCAG 2.2 audit toolkit and Chrome extension. Recipient of Tech Mahindra's ACE Award 2023 for outstanding delivery on a global accessibility program, and recognized at WWW2011 as Youngest Web Researcher.

CORE COMPETENCIES AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Accessibility Standards and Frameworks:** WCAG 2.0 / 2.1 / 2.2 (Levels A, AA, AAA), WAI-ARIA 1.2 and 1.3 Authoring Practices, Section 508 (US Rehabilitation Act), Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA Title III), EN 301 549 (EU Accessibility Mandate), PDF/UA (ISO 14289), AODA, GIGW 3.0, RPwD Act 2016, SEBI Digital Accessibility Mandate.
- **Screen Readers and Assistive Technology:** JAWS, NVDA, Narrator (Windows), Apple VoiceOver (macOS, iOS and iPadOS), Google TalkBack (Android), Orca (Linux), ChromeVox (ChromeOS).
- **Assistive Hardware and Input Methods:** Freedom Scientific Focus 40 Blue refreshable braille display, keyboard-only interaction testing.
- **Auditing, Strategy and Remediation Architecture:** Accessibility Conformance Reports (ACR based on VPAT 2.5), shift-left SDLC integration, technical remediation playbooks for front-end engineers, design system and component architecture covering complex data visualization, charts, dynamic modals and multi-step transaction flows, automated test script strategy and site crawl engines.
- **Platforms and Tooling:** Windows, macOS, Linux, iOS, Android, Microsoft Office suite, PDF accessibility tooling, browser developer tools and accessibility trees.
- **Leadership and Enablement:** Leading diverse testing teams including Persons with Disabilities, cross-functional stakeholder management, technical mentorship for engineering and UI/UX teams, Accessibility Champions programs, executive workshops.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Virtusa Systems India Pvt. Ltd. | Accessibility Test Architect

March 2024 to Present | Chennai, India

Client: Bank of Montreal (OLBB, Online Banking for Business) | March 2025 to Present

- **Lead Accessibility Architect:** Govern end-to-end accessibility evaluation and architectural remediation across BMO's customer-facing web applications, native mobile apps (iOS and Android), and transactional digital documents.

- **Measurable Defect Reduction:** Spearheaded a targeted remediation roadmap and developer guidance framework that reduced critical accessibility defects by 73% across two consecutive major release cycles.
- **WCAG 2.2 and Document Compliance:** Enforced strict compliance with WCAG 2.2 Level AA. Led automated and manual validation for high-volume digital statements and PDFs, ensuring full PDF/UA and WCAG alignment.
- **VPAT 2.5 and Technical Playbooks:** Standardized the creation and governance of Accessibility Conformance Reports (ACR based on VPAT 2.5) and authored cross-platform technical remediation playbooks for development squads.

Client: Dun & Bradstreet | April 2024 to February 2025

- **Lead Accessibility Consultant:** Acted as lead accessibility SME for the flagship Risk Analytics web application, guaranteeing full compliance with WCAG 2.2 Level AA.
- **Complex UI and ARIA Implementation:** Architected expert-level WAI-ARIA implementation strategies for intricate data visualization components, interactive charting widgets, and risk analytics dashboards.
- **Shift-Left Champions Program:** Established an Accessibility Champions program across design and development squads, providing technical mentorship to UI/UX designers and engineers to resolve defects early in the SDLC.

Tech Mahindra | Accessibility Test Lead and SME

November 2019 to March 2024 | Hyderabad and Chennai, India

Client: Google India

- **Team Leadership:** Led, managed, and mentored a high-performing accessibility testing team of 15 engineers, including Persons with Disabilities, executing Google's global accessibility standards.
- **Engineering Enablement across 12 Teams:** Designed and delivered hands-on accessibility training programs that enabled 12 distinct product engineering teams to independently audit, test with screen readers, and ship accessible code.
- **End-to-End Program Delivery:** Managed project timelines, provided deep technical remediation support to development teams, and collaborated across global cross-functional stakeholders.
- **Cross-Platform Validation:** Conducted comprehensive audits across Android, ChromeOS, and desktop web, using TalkBack, ChromeVox, NVDA, and JAWS.
- **ACE Award 2023:** Honored with the ACE Award 2023, Tech Mahindra's highest individual performance recognition, for exceptional delivery and leadership on a global accessibility engagement.

HCL Technologies | Accessibility Technical Lead

July 2014 to October 2019 | Chennai, India

Client: Google India (Google Play)

- **Sole End-User Accessibility Specialist:** Served as the dedicated primary accessibility tester and SME for the Google Play web and developer platform ecosystems.
- **Audit Execution and Defect Tracking:** Executed thorough accessibility test suites against W3C WCAG standards and internal Google checklists, logging and verifying defects through enterprise issue-tracking workflows.
- **Documentation and VPAT Standards:** Authored comprehensive audit reports, drafted formal compliance statements, and created reusable documentation standards for cross-team remediation.

Prakat Solutions | Accessibility Tester and Consultant

February 2011 to June 2014 | Bengaluru, India

Client: Oracle Financial Services and global enterprise clients

- **Large-Scale Portfolio Auditing:** Evaluated accessibility across 250+ enterprise websites, internal web applications, PDF documents, and Flash solutions against Section 508 and WCAG standards.

- **VPAT and Compliance Documentation:** Formulated detailed accessibility statements, assisted in VPAT generation, and delivered technical consulting on remediation strategies.
- **Advocacy and Team Buy-In:** Advocated for inclusive design principles across client development teams, securing organizational buy-in for digital accessibility.

Mphasis (an HP Company) | Technical Support Engineer, Level 2

April 2009 to September 2010 | Pune, India

- **Enterprise Support:** Handled complex Tier-2 customer queries covering HP hardware architecture, software diagnostics, and operating system troubleshooting.

PRODUCT INNOVATION AND OPEN-SOURCE PROJECTS

AMASAMYA, Open-Source Digital Accessibility Audit Suite | Creator and Lead Architect

2024 to Present

- **Open-Source Innovation:** Independently conceived, architected, and shipped AMASAMYA (akhileshmalani.com/amasamya), an open-source accessibility auditing toolkit that makes enterprise-grade accessibility testing free to use.
- **Chrome Extension Architecture:** Engineered a browser extension with 24 automated WCAG 2.2 audit engines, multi-page site crawl of up to 200 pages per run, and a screen-reader and keyboard-first side-panel interface with ARIA live polite-region diff announcements.
- **Free Online Accessibility Checker:** Built and launched a web-based HTML validator and compliance learning platform giving developers instant WCAG 2.2 AA issue categorization, severity ranking, and actionable fix guidance.

HONORS, AWARDS AND THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

- **ACE Award, 2023, Tech Mahindra:** Highest organizational performance award, conferred for leadership, subject matter expertise, and delivery across a global accessibility engagement.
- **Youngest Web Researcher, 2011, World Wide Web Conference (WWW2011):** Recognized at the international conference in Hyderabad for assistive technology research: an Android-based Indian currency recognition application for visually impaired users.
- **Invited Speaker, NASSCOM BPO Summit, 2010:** Presented on digital inclusion, accessibility in IT infrastructure, and career enablement for Persons with Disabilities.
- **Keynotes and Corporate Workshops:** Delivers signature sessions including 'What Happens When a Blind User Tries Your Product', live screen-reader debugging workshops, and corporate seminars on WCAG 2.2, the RPwD Act 2016, and SEBI accessibility compliance.
- **Industry Publications:** Publishes technical guides and accessibility analyses at akhileshmalani.com/blog, covering banking accessibility breakdowns, ARIA best practices, and shift-left testing methodology.

EDUCATION

- **Bachelor of Arts (B.A.), English Literature:** Loyola College, University of Madras, Chennai | 2005 to 2008
- **Higher Senior Secondary Certificate (Arts):** Netraheen Vikas Sansthan, Jodhpur, Rajasthan | 2003 to 2005
- **Senior Secondary Certificate (Arts):** Netraheen Vikas Sansthan, Jodhpur, Rajasthan | 2001 to 2003

PERSONAL DETAILS

- **Languages:** English (fluent), Hindi (native), Marwari (native), Tamil (conversational).
- **Interests and Community Involvement:** Music as a vocalist and multi-instrumentalist, assistive technology research and development, mentoring and career guidance for visually impaired professionals.